

Q3. (a) Write a note on the cultural Materialism in Anthropology

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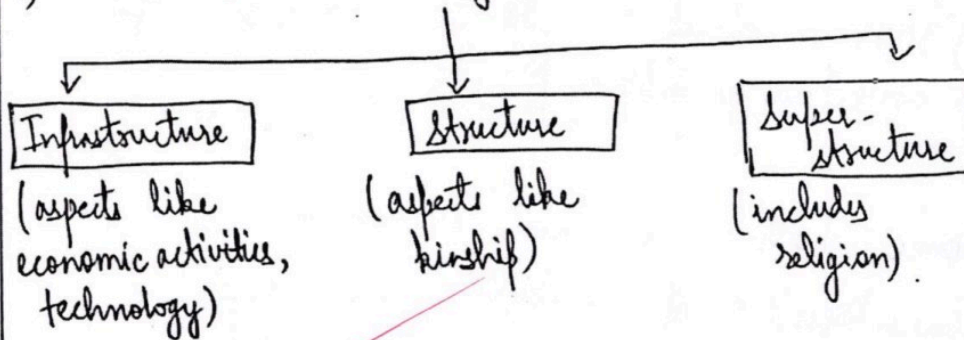
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The concept of cultural materialism was given by Malvin Harris in his book 'The Rise of Anthropological Theory (1955)'

Through cultural materialism, Harris wanted to create a pan scientific society based on logical & rational thinking.

Basic concepts

1) Harris divided society into three parts:



2) He argued that infrastructure of a system indeed influences its structure and super-structure

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3) Thus, the material aspects in a system like economic activities & technology indeed influenced superstructure like religion

Case study: In Hindu society, cows are considered sacred, because they are an important source of milk, butter and cheese. Hence, this has influenced the culture & religion. Thus, they are vowed as 'sacred animals'.

Economic activities $\xrightarrow{\text{influenced}}$ Religion

Criticism

i) Roy Rappaport in 'Gifts for Ancestors (1965)' argued that religion can also influence aspects of structure & infrastructure.

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- 2) Marxists termed this materialism as 'vulgar materialism'
- 3) Post modernists argued that the approach by Harris was strictly too scientific.

Methodology → Harris used the etic approach
i.e. observing society through
scientific and rational way.

Despite criticism, the etic approach championed
by Harris added a new scientific dimension
to the anthropology.

X/K